The Ready Word

The interview prep sheet

Walk in prepared, walk out remembered.

Everything a leader should settle before a media interview, in one place. For CEOs, comms leads and chiefs of staff. Work through it top to bottom when the request comes in, and again the day before.

If you are preparing on the CEO's behalf

Comms leads and chiefs of staff often build the prep alone. Some notes for you:

The minimum to get from the CEO

1. One key message: what they want the audience to remember.
2. Three bullet points that support it.
3. One topic to avoid.

It doesn't need to be polished. A voice note, a few lines in a note or a rough email is enough, and it gives you their own words to work from.

Draw a red thread

Read what the company and the CEO have published recently: press releases, blog posts, thought leadership and earlier interviews. As a rule of thumb, reuse **about a third** of the messages, proof points and phrasing. This:

- makes the CEO comfortable, because much of it is already familiar
- keeps the story consistent from one appearance to the next
- builds material to reuse in future campaigns

The rest should be new, so the journalist still gets something worth reporting.

- **Don't wait for every answer.** If approvals stall or stakeholders are too busy to reply, fill the gaps from information that is already public: annual and quarterly reports, press releases, the company website and the CEO's earlier interviews. For the wider picture, use industry research such as sector statistics, trade body reports and analyst coverage.
- **Mark where every point comes from.** Tag each one in the prep document, for example *[Public: Q2 report, p. 4]*, *[Industry: trade body report 2026]* or *[Awaiting approval]*. The CEO then knows at a glance what is confirmed, and what to keep general.
- **Set an approval deadline.** Anything not approved by then stays out, or is said only in the form that is already public.
- **Keep the brief to two pages,** and get it to the CEO at least a day before.
- **Write the one-line quotes for them** (see section 3). It is the most useful thing you can hand over.

1 Before you say yes

Get the answers in writing from the journalist or producer.

- [ ] **Who and where:** the journalist, the outlet and its audience
- [ ] **The story:** what the piece is about, and why now
- [ ] **The format:** live or recorded, print or broadcast, length, on or off the record
- [ ] **Who else:** other people interviewed, including competitors or critics
- [ ] **The deadline:** when it publishes or airs
- [ ] **Your homework:** read or watch the journalist's last three pieces
- [ ] **A journalist check with AI:** ask your AI tool, with web search switched on, to profile the journalist. For example: *"Summarise [name] at [outlet]: their writing or interview style, their articles and interviews from the last six months, the angles they return to, and how they have treated executives in [sector]. Link every source."* Open the links to confirm what it finds.

If the story could hurt you, it is fine to say no, or to answer by written statement instead.

2 Three messages to land

Decide what the audience should remember. If they remember only one thing, it should be message 1.

	Message, in one sentence	Proof: a fact, number or example
1		
2		
3		

- Write each message the way you would say it to a neighbour, not in the language of a press release.
- Aim to land each one at least twice during the interview.
- Have one short story ready that brings message 1 to life.

3 The five hardest questions

Write down the questions you would least like to be asked. For each one, give a short, honest answer, then bridge to one of your messages. Add a one-line quote for each: a short, memorable sentence the journalist is likely to pick up and use.

Hard question	Short, honest answer	Bridge to message	One-line quote to remember

Bridges that sound natural

"What matters most here is..."
"The bigger picture is..."
"What I can tell you is..."

Never

- Say "no comment". Say why you can't answer instead: "That's still under negotiation, so I can't go into detail."
- Guess. "I'll check and come back to you" is a complete answer, as long as you do.
- Repeat a negative phrase from the question. It becomes the headline.
- Say anything "off the record" unless you agreed it in writing beforehand.

4 Check every fact you might say

A wrong number in an interview stays online forever. Check each one against its source, and have someone else check it too.

- ☐ **Financials:** revenue, growth, margins, guidance. Only what is already public.
- ☐ **People:** headcount, hires, departures, and how names and titles are spelled
- ☐ **Customers and partners:** name only those who have agreed to be named
- ☐ **Dates:** launches, deals, milestones
- ☐ **Market claims:** "the largest", "the first", "the only". Each needs a source.
- ☐ **Disclosure:** if the company is listed, comms or legal have cleared anything price-sensitive
- ☐ **Today's news:** read your own company's and your sector's headlines on the day

5 A 30-minute rehearsal

Have a colleague play the journalist. Rehearse out loud, because answers that read well on paper often run long when spoken.

1. **5 min:** say your three messages out loud, each in under 20 seconds.
2. **10 min:** answer the five hard questions, bridging every time.
3. **10 min:** a fast, unscripted mock interview, with the colleague interrupting and pushing back.
4. **5 min:** play it back. Cut jargon and long answers, and note where the messages got lost.

For TV or radio, record the rehearsal on a phone. For video calls, check your camera, light and sound at the same time.

6 On the day, and after

- [ ] Re-read your three messages and the five hard questions. Don't memorise whole answers; they sound scripted. Remember only the one-line quote for each, and fall back on it whenever an answer starts to drift.
- [ ] Assume everything is on the record, before and after the recording.
- [ ] Pause before you answer. A short silence reads as thought, not doubt.
- [ ] Finish with your main message, even if they don't ask: *"If there's one thing your readers should take away..."*
- [ ] Within the hour, send any figures or facts you promised.
- [ ] Ask to check your quotes for facts. In Norway this is common practice, but it covers your own quotes only.
- [ ] When it's published, note what landed and what didn't for next time.

7 Audit the finished prep with AI

Once the template is filled in, give it to your AI tool for a final review. Use a tool your company has approved, and leave out anything confidential or price-sensitive that is not yet public. Then paste the prompt below, with the filled-in document attached.

COPY THIS PROMPT

You are a senior media trainer and fact-checker. Attached is an interview prep document for [CEO name, title, company], who will be interviewed by [journalist] at [outlet] on [date] about [topic]. The audience is [audience].

Review it and report back in this order:

1. **Facts.** List every factual claim: numbers, names, titles, dates, customers and market claims such as “the largest” or “the first”. Mark each as Verified (with a source link), Can’t verify or Wrong (with the correct figure and source). Flag any point tagged [Awaiting approval], and anything that looks confidential or price-sensitive.
2. **Risk.** Flag anything controversial, legally sensitive, easy to quote out of context, or in conflict with what the company or CEO has said publicly before. For each, suggest a safer wording.
3. **Missing questions.** Based on the journalist’s recent work and the news, list the three hardest questions the document does not yet prepare for.
4. **Messages.** Are the three messages clear, distinct and backed by proof? Do they follow the company’s recent public messaging?
5. **One-line quotes.** Is each one short, memorable and safe to print on its own? Suggest a stronger version where one falls flat.
6. **Length.** The brief should fit on two pages. Each spoken answer should take under 45 seconds, roughly 100 words. Flag anything longer.
7. **Clarity and grammar.** Flag jargon, long sentences, unclear wording and errors in grammar, spelling or consistency.

Then give a score out of 10 for how ready the CEO is, with one sentence on why. List the specific changes that would make it a 10/10, most important first.

Rules: do not invent facts or sources. If you cannot check something, say so. Do not rewrite the whole document; point to the line and suggest the fix. Be direct; this is for an internal review.

Check its findings yourself before you change anything. AI can be wrong about facts, too.

Short on time, or are the stakes too high to do it alone?

I prepare executives for interviews and panels, from the briefing to a rehearsal on the day before. Walk in prepared, walk out remembered.

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